

AI Training Source Material: Bias Indicators in Student Evaluations of Minoritized Faculty

With Supporting Evidence from the Literature

Revised and Expanded Edition — Version 3

Preface: Four Forms of Bias in Student Evaluations

Research identifies four broad and overlapping categories of bias in student evaluations of minoritized faculty that AI models must be trained to detect:

Type 1 — Direct Identity Bias: Explicit identity-based language targeting the instructor's personality, appearance, authority, accent, sexual orientation, gender identity, or cultural background.

Type 2 — Proxy Bias (Pedagogical Dissatisfaction): Complaints framed in ostensibly neutral, pedagogical terms — grading, feedback timing, workload, syllabus clarity, course structure, LMS use, rubric design, assignment expectations — that appear legitimate but are contaminated by instructor identity.

Type 3 — Stigmatized Identity Bias: Bias rooted not in general race or gender categories, but in the specific social meanings attached to a particular national origin, ethnicity, religion, sexual orientation, or gender identity that has been systematically stigmatized in the broader culture. This operates through distinct psychological mechanisms (e.g., disgust, perceived deviance, "forever foreigner" tropes) and requires identity-specific training data.

Type 4 — Deliberate Defamation: Content that goes beyond bias to constitute targeted harassment, fabricated accusation, unadjudicated misconduct claims, or coordinated reputational attacks. This requires a different institutional response than implicit bias.

The foundational evidence for Type 2 bias is this: even with all course elements held constant — content, assignments, schedules, and communications — women and faculty of color received lower scores than white men (Chávez & Mitchell, 2020). When pedagogy is identical and complaints still differ by instructor identity, those complaints must be explained by something other than pedagogy. Additionally, even student comments about instructor characteristics that should be somewhat objective — such as how much time it takes to return assignments — contain bias (Inside Higher Ed, 2019).

All four types must be flagged, analyzed in context, and reviewed by qualified human evaluators before any personnel determination is made.

CATEGORY 1: Personality & Temperament

(Type 1 — Direct Identity Bias)

Research shows that faculty of color and women faculty are disproportionately described in student evaluations using affective and temperamental language rather than intellectual or pedagogical language. Harlow (2003) and Tuitt et al. (2009) document that open-ended evaluation comments frequently characterize faculty of color as "too loud," "intimidating," and having "a personal bias against students." Motro et al. (2022) find that Black women's professional assertiveness is systematically misread as irrational anger, resulting in lower performance evaluations. Smith and Hawkins (2011) find that Black faculty receive the lowest student evaluation scores of any racial group, and that open-ended comments disproportionately attribute negative personality traits to Black instructors.

Direct terms:

- angry, aggressive, hostile, intimidating, scary, threatening
- bossy, pushy, controlling, domineering
- mean, rude, cold, harsh, abrasive, combative
- annoying, irritating, too sensitive, overly emotional, defensive
- uptight, intense, difficult, unapproachable, standoffish
- unfriendly, unpleasant, condescending, arrogant, dismissive

Phrases:

- "has a chip on their shoulder"
- "seems angry all the time"
- "gets defensive when questioned"
- "takes things too personally"
- "has an attitude"
- "makes students feel uncomfortable"
- "very off-putting" / "hard to be around"
- "seems like they don't want to be here"
- "rubs students the wrong way"
- "went on a rant" / "had an outburst" / "overreacted" / "blew up at students"

Key citations: Harlow (2003); Tuitt et al. (2009); Motro et al. (2022); Smith & Hawkins (2011)

CATEGORY 2: Authority & Competence Challenges

(Type 1 — Direct Identity Bias)

Faculty of color face a well-documented "presumption of incompetence" in the academy (Gutiérrez y Muhs et al., 2012). This presumption surfaces in student evaluations as challenges to credentials, expertise, and authority that rarely appear in evaluations of white male peers. Chávez and Mitchell (2020) find that even in quasi-experimental designs where all course content is identical, faculty of color receive lower competence ratings than white instructors. Anderson and Smith (2005) document that students hold preconceived notions about faculty of color that negatively shape their assessments of instructional ability before a course even begins.

Direct terms:

- unqualified, incompetent, unknowledgeable, unprepared
- disorganized, scattered, confusing, unclear, ineffective, inexperienced, lost, clueless

Phrases:

- "doesn't know the material"
- "not qualified to teach this"
- "doesn't seem to know what they're talking about"
- "hard to follow" / "all over the place" / "seems unprepared"
- "not a real expert" / "questions their own knowledge"
- "couldn't answer basic questions"
- "students knew more than the professor"
- "not sure why they're teaching this" / "seems out of their depth"
- "not a real professor" / "I've had better teachers in high school"

Key citations: Gutiérrez y Muhs et al. (2012); Chávez & Mitchell (2020); Anderson & Smith (2005); Reid (2010)

CATEGORY 3: Accent & Language Bias

(Type 1 — Direct Identity Bias)

A large-scale analysis of 26,659 student comments from 852 health professions courses found that faculty with racial, ethnic, and accent differences received more critical feedback and less praise than their white, General American-accented counterparts, even when instructional quality was equivalent (PubMed, 2025). Chávez and Mitchell (2020) describe this as a form of "shifting standards" bias in which non-native accents are evaluated not against a neutral

benchmark but against an implicit white, native-English-speaking norm. Rubin and Smith (1990) demonstrate that students rate comprehension lower when they believe an instructor is a non-native English speaker, even when the audio content is identical.

Importantly, accent bias and cultural identity bias can operate independently: a faculty member who speaks fluent, unaccented English may still face evaluative penalties rooted in the stigmatized social meaning of their ethnic or national identity (see Category 13: Stigmatized Ethnic and National Identity Bias).

Direct terms:

- accent, hard to understand, incomprehensible, unclear speech
- mumbles, broken English, foreign, thick accent

Phrases:

- "hard to understand because of their accent"
- "couldn't understand half of what they said"
- "needs to work on their English"
- "speaks too fast / too slow"
- "hard to follow because of the way they speak"
- "the accent made it impossible to learn"
- "should not be teaching if they can't speak clearly"
- "English is not their first language and it shows"
- "hard to understand, not sure if it's the accent or just them"

Key citations: Subtirelu (2015); Rubin & Smith (1990); Chávez & Mitchell (2020); Heffernan (2022); PubMed (2025)

CATEGORY 4: Relatability & Fit

(Type 1 — Direct Identity Bias)

Relatability complaints in student evaluations often function as expressions of cultural or racial incongruity — the sense that an instructor does not conform to students' preconceived image of what a professor looks or sounds like. Reid (2010) finds that students' preconceptions about faculty are shaped by racialized and gendered expectations, and that faculty who deviate from those expectations are rated lower on interpersonal dimensions. This dynamic is particularly acute for faculty of color at predominantly white institutions (Pittman, 2010). The "forever foreigner" trope — which marks faculty as permanently outside the national or institutional community regardless of citizenship, language fluency, or years of residence — generates

relatability complaints even against native-born, native-English-speaking faculty whose ethnic identity is stigmatized (see Category 13).

Direct terms:

- unrelatable, disconnected, distant, out of place, awkward
- stiff, robotic, weird, odd, unusual

Phrases:

- "doesn't connect with students" / "not relatable at all"
- "seems uncomfortable up there" / "doesn't fit in here"
- "not the type of professor I expected"
- "seems out of place" / "doesn't seem to belong here"
- "doesn't understand students" / "not like other professors"
- "very different from what I'm used to"
- "doesn't seem to get us"
- "feels like they're from a different world"

Key citations: Reid (2010); Pittman (2010); Anderson & Smith (2005); Chávez & Mitchell (2020)

CATEGORY 5: Gendered Language Patterns

(Type 1 — Direct Identity Bias)

Large-scale analyses of student evaluation language reveal systematic differences in how students describe women versus men faculty. Schmidt's (2015) analysis of over 14 million Rate My Professors reviews finds that men are far more likely to be described as "brilliant," "genius," and "funny," while women are more likely to be called "bossy," "mean," and "pushy." MacNeill et al. (2014) demonstrate in an experimental study that identical online instructors received different qualitative descriptions based solely on perceived gender. Boring et al. (2016) find that women faculty are held to higher standards of organization and professionalism and are more likely to be evaluated on physical appearance and emotional affect than male peers.

Terms applied disproportionately to women faculty:

- bossy, motherly, nurturing, emotional, hysterical, dramatic, sensitive
- frumpy, pretty, attractive, ugly, appearance-related descriptors (hair, clothing, weight)
- shrill, nagging, sweet, bubbly, ditzy, scattered, disorganized

Phrases:

- "seemed nervous and unsure of herself"
- "needs to be more assertive"
- "too strict / not strict enough" / "too nice / too mean"
- "should smile more"
- "very motherly, which I liked / didn't like"
- "dresses [description]" / "looks [description]"
- "acts like she knows everything"
- "tries too hard to be liked"
- "doesn't command respect" / "let students walk all over her"
- "came across as weak" / "came across as too aggressive for a woman"
- "not what I expected from a female professor"

Key citations: Schmidt (2015); MacNeill et al. (2014); Boring et al. (2016); Sprague & Massoni (2005); Mengel et al. (2019)

CATEGORY 6: Racialized Language Patterns

(Type 1 — Direct Identity Bias)

Smith and Hawkins (2011) find that Black faculty receive the lowest student evaluation scores of any racial group, and that open-ended comments disproportionately attribute negative personality traits to Black instructors. Pittman (2010) documents that faculty of color at predominantly white institutions frequently report being perceived as threatening, aggressive, or insufficiently deferential. Subtirelu (2015) analyzes Rate My Professors data and finds race- and language-based bias operating simultaneously in student evaluations of mathematics instructors.

Direct terms:

- loud, intimidating, aggressive, angry, threatening, foreign, different, unexpected

Phrases:

- "too loud" / "very intimidating"
- "makes everything about race"
- "seems angry" / "has a chip on their shoulder"
- "plays favorites" (*when directed at faculty of color by majority students*)
- "biased against white students"
- "doesn't like students like me"
- "not what I expected" / "surprising for someone in this position"

- "not the typical professor"
- "hard to relate to someone so different"
- "brings their background into everything"
- "I felt singled out" / "treated me differently because I'm [identity]"

Key citations: Smith & Hawkins (2011); Pittman (2010); Subtirelu (2015); Harris-Perry (2011); Harlow (2003)

CATEGORY 7: Bias Claims Turned Outward

(Type 1 — Direct Identity Bias)

A distinct and well-documented pattern in evaluations of minoritized faculty involves students attributing their own discomfort to instructor bias rather than to the challenging nature of the material. Lazos (2012) and Pittman (2010) document that faculty of color who teach content related to systemic inequality are significantly more likely to receive accusations of bias, political agenda-pushing, or unfair treatment of majority-group students. This pattern is described by Lazos (2012) as a form of "racial taxation."

Direct terms:

- biased, unfair, discriminatory, prejudiced, one-sided, agenda-driven, political

Phrases:

- "has a personal agenda" / "pushes their own views"
- "too political" / "only teaches one perspective"
- "biased against [majority group]" / "makes students feel guilty"
- "forces their opinions on us" / "not objective" / "very one-sided"
- "doesn't respect other viewpoints"
- "shuts down opinions they don't agree with"
- "penalizes students who disagree" / "is clearly biased"
- "has a political agenda" / "doesn't allow free speech" / "silences students"
- "targets students who disagree"
- "grades based on whether you agree with them"
- "punishes conservative / traditional views"
- "creates a hostile environment for [majority group] students"

Key citations: Lazos (2012); Pittman (2010); Harlow (2003); Gutiérrez y Muhs et al. (2012)

CATEGORY 8: Course Content Complaints as Proxy Bias

(Type 1/Type 2 — Direct and Proxy Bias)

When students complain about course subject matter in ways that implicitly or explicitly challenge the instructor's right to teach it, those complaints often function as proxy attacks on the instructor's identity and legitimacy. Student evaluations of teaching express more negative performance evaluations of faculty when diversity and inclusion topics are the focus of the courses being evaluated (ScienceDirect, 2022).

Direct terms:

- political, one-sided, biased, irrelevant, unnecessary, forced, preachy, propaganda, indoctrination

Phrases:

- "this class is too political"
- "we only talked about race/gender/identity"
- "too much focus on [equity topic]"
- "this wasn't what I expected the class to be about"
- "felt like propaganda" / "felt like indoctrination"
- "I didn't feel comfortable expressing my views"
- "I felt targeted / attacked"
- "made me feel bad about being white / male / straight / etc."
- "shouldn't bring identity politics into the classroom"
- "not relevant to the subject matter"
- "turned every topic into a race / gender issue"
- "the class was more about their identity than the content"
- "felt like I was being lectured about social justice"
- "this is not what college is for" / "very preachy"
- "pushed a liberal / progressive agenda" / "not balanced"
- "class should be about [subject], not politics"

Key citations: Gutiérrez y Muhs et al. (2012); Lazos (2012); Pittman (2010); ScienceDirect (2022)

(Type 2 — Proxy Bias)

This is the most administratively dangerous category of bias because complaints appear legitimate, objective, and content-focused. Research establishes that complaints about grading, feedback timing, workload, rubric clarity, syllabus organization, course structure, LMS use, assignment design, and due dates are systematically more negative in evaluations of women and faculty of color — even when the pedagogical practices are identical to those of white male peers. Even student comments about instructor characteristics that should be somewhat objective, such as how much time it takes to return assignments, contain bias (Inside Higher Ed, 2019). This category is organized by the type of pedagogical complaint.

9A. Grading and Assessment Complaints

Grade satisfaction — not instructional quality, workload, or grading stringency — drives evaluation scores (Kogan et al., 2022). Women and faculty of color are penalized more severely than white male peers for identical grading decisions. Male instructors are less penalized for being tough graders (St. Olaf IEA, 2025). Students are also more likely to expect special favors from female professors and react badly when those expectations aren't met (UNC Charlotte ADVANCE, 2023).

Proxy bias phrases — Grading:

- "grading is unfair" / "rubrics are unclear"
- "I never know what they want" / "grading seems arbitrary"
- "my grade doesn't reflect my effort"
- "graded too harshly" / "the grading criteria don't make sense"
- "there's no clear rubric" / "inconsistent grading"
- "grades students differently" / "seems to grade based on opinion"
- "penalizes students who think differently"
- "grades me down for no reason"
- "not sure how to get a good grade in this class"
- "you can't win no matter what you do"

Proxy bias phrases — Exams and Assessments:

- "exams don't reflect what we studied"
- "the test was too hard" / "tests are unfair"
- "exam questions were confusing"
- "didn't prepare us for the exams"

- "the exam didn't match the material"
- "tests are trick questions" / "exams are unnecessarily difficult"
- "quizzes are too frequent"

Key citations: Kogan et al. (2022); Buser et al. (2022); Boring et al. (2016); St. Olaf IEA (2025); Sprague & Massoni (2005)

9B. Feedback Timing and Responsiveness Complaints

A meta-analysis showed that bias affects how students rate even putatively objective aspects of teaching, such as how promptly assignments are graded (Boring et al., 2016). There are higher expectations of women and people of color for availability and clarity in the classroom, and a willingness to excuse shortcomings of male faculty because of the assumption they're engaged in other "important" work (Inside Higher Ed, 2019).

Proxy bias phrases — Feedback:

- "takes forever to return assignments"
- "feedback is not helpful" / "doesn't give enough feedback"
- "feedback is too harsh / too vague"
- "doesn't explain what went wrong"
- "feedback doesn't help me improve"
- "grades without explaining why" / "comments don't make sense"
- "feedback is inconsistent"

Proxy bias phrases — Responsiveness and Availability:

- "never responds to emails" / "takes too long to respond"
- "not accessible outside of class" / "doesn't hold enough office hours"
- "hard to reach" / "not supportive enough"
- "doesn't care about student success"
- "makes you feel stupid for asking questions"
- "unapproachable when you need help" / "doesn't make time for students"

Key citations: Boring et al. (2016); Kogan et al. (2022); Inside Higher Ed (2019); Sprague & Massoni (2005); Hochschild (1983)

9C. Workload and Rigor Complaints

The consumerization of higher education has produced a well-documented dynamic in which

academic rigor is penalized in student evaluations. Faculty members who teach demanding courses may receive lower ratings not because they teach poorly, but because students conflate challenge with poor instruction (Chronicle, 2025). This dynamic is not identity-neutral: because minoritized faculty already face challenges to their professional authority, they are less able to reduce rigor without further eroding students' perception of their competence.

Proxy bias phrases — Workload:

- "way too much work" / "unreasonable expectations" / "expects too much"
- "the workload is not manageable" / "too much reading"
- "assignments don't make sense" / "not worth the effort required"
- "other professors don't assign this much"
- "the course is harder than it needs to be"
- "this class is too demanding" / "the workload is overwhelming"
- "not realistic for a [level] course"

Proxy bias phrases — Rigor:

- "the course is too hard" / "standards are too high"
- "impossible to get a good grade"
- "sets students up to fail" / "unrealistic expectations"
- "nitpicks everything" / "expects graduate-level work"
- "penalizes minor mistakes" / "this isn't a fair class"

Key citations: Kogan et al. (2022); Marsh & Roche (2000); St. Olaf IEA (2025); Chronicle (2025); Minding the Campus (2025)

9D. Syllabus, Course Structure, and Organization Complaints

The same syllabus or course structure, when attributed to a woman or person of color, is perceived as less organized and less clear than when attributed to a white male instructor. Women are more likely than men to be described as either "professional" or "unprofessional," and either "organized" or "disorganized," reflecting greater scrutiny of women's organizational self-presentation (Schmidt, 2015). Male instructors are perceived as more organized and prompt in providing feedback than female peers, independent of actual performance (UNC Charlotte ADVANCE, 2023).

Proxy bias phrases — Syllabus:

- "the syllabus is confusing" / "the syllabus is unclear"
- "doesn't follow the syllabus" / "the syllabus doesn't prepare you for the class"

- "the syllabus is unrealistic" / "expectations aren't clear from the syllabus"
- "the syllabus changes all the time"

Proxy bias phrases — Organization and Structure:

- "disorganized" / "I never know what's due" / "due dates keep changing"
- "no clear structure" / "the course is all over the place"
- "unclear expectations" / "changes things last minute"
- "the course doesn't flow" / "not clear what the point of the assignments is"
- "hard to know what to prioritize" / "no clear learning objectives"

Proxy bias phrases — LMS and Materials:

- "hard to follow the course on [LMS]"
- "slides are not posted on time" / "materials are not organized online"
- "the course page is a mess" / "can't find anything on Canvas / Blackboard / Moodle"
- "doesn't post materials in advance"
- "lecture notes are unhelpful" / "slides don't match what was taught"

Key citations: Boring et al. (2016); Schmidt (2015); Sprague & Massoni (2005); UNC Charlotte ADVANCE (2023); MacNeill et al. (2014)

9E. Class Delivery and Instructional Clarity Complaints

Research consistently shows that male instructors are perceived as more clear, more accurate, and more enthusiastic than female peers teaching identically designed courses (St. Olaf IEA, 2025). These perceptions are projections of identity-based expectations rather than assessments of actual instructional quality.

Proxy bias phrases — Instructional Clarity:

- "doesn't explain things clearly" / "hard to follow in class"
- "lectures aren't useful" / "goes off topic" / "doesn't stick to the material"
- "hard to understand what they're trying to say"
- "explanations are confusing" / "doesn't know how to teach"
- "talks too fast / too slow" / "not clear what the main points are"

Proxy bias phrases — Class Time and Engagement:

- "wastes class time" / "class is unproductive" / "class feels unplanned"
- "doesn't use class time well" / "boring lectures" / "just reads from the slides"

- "doesn't engage the class" / "class is hard to pay attention in"
- "doesn't make the material interesting" / "not energetic enough"

Proxy bias phrases — Classroom Management:

- "loses control of the class" / "lets students walk all over them"
- "doesn't command respect" / "class is chaotic"
- "students don't take the class seriously" / "hard to focus with how the class is run"

Key citations: St. Olaf IEA (2025); UNC Charlotte ADVANCE (2023); MacNeill et al. (2014); Chávez & Mitchell (2020); Boring et al. (2016)

CATEGORY 10: The Double-Bind of Rigor

(Type 2 — Proxy Bias; NEW CATEGORY)

The double-bind of rigor operates as a closed logical trap producing negative evaluations regardless of pedagogical outcome. When students find a course difficult and earn lower grades, they blame the instructor. When students succeed in a challenging course, they credit themselves — describing their achievement as occurring *despite* poor teaching rather than *because* of good teaching. The instructor is penalized in both scenarios. This trap is not symmetrical across instructor identity: male instructors are less penalized for being tough graders (St. Olaf IEA, 2025), and the presumption of incompetence (Gutiérrez y Muhs et al., 2012) causes students to interpret rigor as evidence of poor instruction rather than high standards when the instructor is a woman or person of color.

The research compounds this paradox: more rigorous and experienced professors had students with lower evaluations and exam scores in introductory courses but significantly better performance in follow-on courses (Preprints.org, 2025). In high-credibility studies with random instructor assignments, higher SET ratings coincide with weaker performance in follow-on courses (Carrell & West, 2010; Braga et al., 2014). The instructors who teach most effectively for long-term learning are the same instructors who receive the lowest evaluation scores — and because those instructors are disproportionately minoritized, the system penalizes both excellence and equity simultaneously.

10A. The Rigor Penalty — Penalized for High Standards

Phrases indicating rigor misread as poor instruction:

- "too hard for no reason"
- "the grading is unfair" / "unrealistic expectations"

- "other professors don't make it this difficult"
- "sets students up to fail" / "impossible to do well"
- "nitpicks everything" / "takes off points for minor things"
- "the class is harder than it needs to be"
- "penalizes students for not being perfect"
- "doesn't curve even when everyone fails"
- "standards are impossibly high"

Key citations: Carrell & West (2010); Braga et al. (2014); Uttl et al. (2017); Chronicle (2025); Minding the Campus (2025)

10B. The Success Inversion — Denied Credit When Students Succeed

The success inversion occurs when students attribute their learning success to themselves while simultaneously citing poor instruction. This is driven by self-serving attribution bias (the tendency to credit oneself for success and blame external factors for failure) and by the presumption of incompetence, which causes students to explain away evidence of effective teaching from a minoritized instructor.

The "Despite" Formulation — key phrases:

- "I learned despite the poor instruction"
- "had to teach myself" / "figured it out on my own"
- "the book was great, the professor not so much"
- "I had to teach myself most of this but eventually got it"
- "figured things out on my own because the instructor wasn't helpful"
- "would have been a better class with a different professor"
- "learned a lot from YouTube / the readings / my classmates / study groups"
- "managed to get a good grade despite the confusion"
- "survived the class despite..."
- "got through it no thanks to..."
- "the content was interesting even if the teaching wasn't"
- "learned from the textbook, not from class"
- "study groups saved me in this course"
- "made it work despite the instructor's lack of clarity"

Asymmetric Attribution Map for AI Training:

Outcome	Likely attribution for white male instructor	Likely biased attribution for minoritized instructor
Student struggles	"This material is hard" / "I need to study more"	"The professor can't teach"
Student succeeds	"The professor taught me well"	"I figured it out myself"
Course is challenging	"Rigorous and intellectually demanding"	"Disorganized and unfair"
Course is accessible	"Clear and well-structured"	"Not rigorous enough"

Key citations: Gutiérrez y Muhs et al. (2012); Lazos (2012); Uttl et al. (2017); Carrell & West (2010); Weiner (1985)

10C. The Double Double-Bind — Penalized for Both High and Low Rigor

The double-bind extends beyond the rigor-leniency axis to create a no-win evaluative environment. The key AI training signal is the **no-win pattern**: when a single instructor receives complaints on both ends of a spectrum simultaneously (e.g., "too hard" AND "not academic enough"), this suggests the complaints are driven by identity bias rather than actual pedagogical problems.

- **Too rigorous:** "unfair," "too demanding," "sets students up to fail"
- **Too lenient:** "not challenging enough," "gave everyone an A," "not a serious course"
- **Too much feedback:** "picks everything apart," "too critical"
- **Too little feedback:** "never explains what went wrong," "vague comments"
- **Too structured:** "rigid," "inflexible," "doesn't adapt to the class"
- **Too unstructured:** "disorganized," "all over the place," "no clear expectations"

Key citations: Sprague & Massoni (2005); Boring et al. (2016); MacNeill et al. (2014); Buser et al. (2022)

CATEGORY 11: Structural & Tonal Tropes

(Type 1 — Direct Identity Bias)

Tone Policing

Tone policing occurs when students criticize the *manner* in which an instructor communicates rather than the substance, and when the same communicative style would not be flagged in a white male peer.

- "too harsh" / "unnecessarily blunt"
- "could have said that more nicely" / "very abrasive delivery"
- "didn't have to be so aggressive about it"
- "the way they said it was offensive"
- "attacked students for asking questions"
- "made me feel stupid for not knowing"
- "condescending tone" / "talked down to students"

Key citations: Sprague & Massoni (2005); Boring et al. (2016); Harlow (2003)

Angry Black Woman / Sapphire Trope

Harris-Perry (2011) theorizes the "Sapphire" or "Angry Black Woman" stereotype as one of the most persistent controlling images applied to Black women, functioning to delegitimize their anger, authority, and expertise. Motro et al. (2022) find empirically that Black women's expressions of anger at work are penalized more severely than identical expressions from white women or men of any race.

- "went on a rant" / "had an outburst"
- "very aggressive, especially for a [woman/professor]"
- "seemed to have a personal problem with [student/group]"
- "overreacted to a simple question" / "blew up at the class"
- "scary when she gets upset" / "students were afraid to participate"
- "intimidating, especially as a Black woman"

Key citations: Harris-Perry (2011); Motro et al. (2022); Harlow (2003); West (2008)

Model Minority Inversion

Asian faculty may be penalized for directness, assertiveness, or authority that violates the "model minority" stereotype of passivity and deference.

- "not as quiet/humble/deferential as I expected"
- "more aggressive than I expected"

- "surprising personality" / "not what I expected based on [background]"

Key citations: Subtirelu (2015); Heffernan (2022); Chávez & Mitchell (2020)

Authority Challenge

The presumption of incompetence (Gutiérrez y Muhs et al., 2012) manifests as explicit or implicit challenges to a faculty member's right to occupy their position.

- "doesn't seem qualified" / "how did they get this job"
- "I've had better professors" / "students knew more than the professor"
- "not a real expert" / "not sure why they're teaching this course"

Key citations: Gutiérrez y Muhs et al. (2012); Reid (2010); Anderson & Smith (2005)

The Double Bind

No behavioral choice is "correct": assertiveness is penalized as aggression, while warmth is penalized as weakness. This double bind extends directly into pedagogical domains — strict grading is "unfair," lenient grading reflects incompetence; high workload is "unreasonable," low workload reflects lack of rigor.

- "too strict" / "too lenient"
- "too cold" / "too emotional"
- "too rigid" / "too disorganized"
- "too harsh" / "too soft"
- "tries too hard" / "doesn't try hard enough"
- "too formal" / "too casual"
- "too much work" / "doesn't challenge students"
- "grades too hard" / "doesn't take grading seriously"

Key citations: Sprague & Massoni (2005); Boring et al. (2016); MacNeill et al. (2014); Buser et al. (2022)

Emotional Labor Expectations

Research consistently shows that women and faculty of color face higher emotional labor expectations from students and are penalized in evaluations when those expectations are not met (Harlow, 2003; Pittman, 2010).

- "not available enough" / "doesn't respond to emails fast enough"
- "not nurturing" / "doesn't seem to care about student success"
- "very cold and robotic" / "no warmth at all" / "felt like just a number"

Key citations: Hochschild (1983); Harlow (2003); Pittman (2010); Sprague & Massoni (2005)

Guilt Narrative

The guilt narrative occurs when majority-group students frame their discomfort with equity-related course content as a form of personal harm inflicted by the instructor.

- "made me feel bad about being [identity]"
- "I felt attacked for being [identity]"
- "targeted students like me" / "made [majority group] students feel unwelcome"
- "created a hostile environment" / "I felt shamed"
- "blamed students for systemic problems"

Key citations: Lazos (2012); Gutiérrez y Muhs et al. (2012); Pittman (2010)

CATEGORY 12: Bias Against LGBTQ+ Faculty

(Type 1 and Type 3 — Direct and Stigmatized Identity Bias; NEW CATEGORY)

Some evidence suggests that LGBTQ+ professors fare worse than their peers in general (Inside Higher Ed, 2021), but there is almost no research on other intersectional identities. Gender identity that does not overtly conform to the binary likely complicates evaluations of teaching further than the existing body of knowledge has even identified (Kreitzer & Sweet-Cushman, 2021). LGBTQ+ faculty must navigate complex relationships with students, including the danger of negative teaching evaluations based solely on their sexual or gender identities (UCI Equity Advising, n.d.).

LGBTQ+ identity bias in SETs has several features that distinguish it from other forms of bias: (1) it is frequently triggered by *disclosure*, making concealment versus authenticity a central professional dilemma; (2) it operates through the "gay agenda" trope — attributing political motivation to any LGBTQ+ presence; and (3) it involves a heteronormative perception distortion (novelty attachment and content substitution) that causes students to overestimate LGBTQ+ content even among otherwise non-hostile students.

12A. The "Gay Agenda" / Political Bias Accusation

Anderson and Kanner (2011) found that college students were more likely to perceive lesbian and gay faculty as being biased and possessing a greater political agenda than their heterosexual counterparts, even when the same syllabi were used by both groups.

Phrases:

- "has a political agenda" / "pushes LGBTQ topics when they're not relevant"
- "too focused on gender/sexuality issues"
- "made the class about their personal life"
- "biased toward [LGBTQ] perspectives"
- "not objective about social issues"
- "turned every topic into a political issue"
- "forced their views on the class"
- "the class felt like an LGBTQ advocacy session"
- "kept bringing up irrelevant personal information"

Key citations: Anderson & Kanner (2011); Ripley et al. (2012); CBE Life Sciences (2024)

12B. Credibility and Competence Challenges Following Disclosure

Russ, Simonds, and Hunt (2002) found that when a male guest speaker identified his partner with a male name in a prepared classroom lecture, he received more than twice as many critical remarks on evaluations as his counterpart who referred to a female partner.

Phrases:

- Lower ratings on competence, qualification, or knowledge after identity disclosure
- Complaints about the instructor's credibility not matched by any specific pedagogical failure
- "Not qualified to teach this topic objectively"
- "Seems to only care about [LGBTQ] issues"
- Suggestions that the instructor's identity disqualifies them from objectivity

Key citations: Russ et al. (2002); Anderson & Kanner (2011); Frontiers in Education (2024)

12C. Heteronormativity-Driven Content Distortion

Ripley, Anderson, McCormack, and Rockett (2012) found that students significantly

overestimated LGBT frequencies and underestimated heterosexual ones when an openly gay instructor used both LGBT and heterosexual examples in teaching. Two concepts explain this:

- **Novelty attachment:** Any LGBTQ+-inclusive content, however proportionally minor, is perceived as outsized because it departs from heteronormative defaults.
- **Content substitution:** Students mentally replace the actual course content with LGBTQ+ content in their memory — so a course spending 10% of its time on LGBTQ+-relevant examples is remembered and evaluated as if primarily about LGBTQ+ topics.

Phrases indicating content distortion:

- "Spent too much time on LGBTQ examples"
- "Everything was about gay/transgender people"
- "The course wasn't what I expected" (*after a single identity-related example*)
- "The personal stuff didn't belong in class"
- Complaints overstating the actual proportion of LGBTQ-related content

Key citations: Ripley et al. (2012); Anderson & Kanner (2011)

12D. Disclosure-Triggered Retaliation

Some students who were out to their classes experienced negative reactions, including discriminatory remarks, retaliation with negative evaluations, and intimidating emails (Frontiers in Education, 2024). This establishes that at least some anti-LGBTQ+ evaluative content is deliberate, not merely unconscious bias.

Phrases and signals:

- Spike in negative evaluation scores following an in-class disclosure or identity-related reference
- Increased critical comments after disclosure with no corresponding change in course structure
- Deliberate misgendering in evaluation language (*use of wrong pronouns*)
- Explicit references to the instructor's sexual orientation or gender identity as a complaint

Key citations: Frontiers in Education (2024); Russ et al. (2002); De Souza (2018)

12E. Discomfort Framed as Harm

Phrases:

- "I didn't feel comfortable in this class"
- "The classroom wasn't a safe space for my views"
- "I felt like my beliefs were attacked"
- "The professor made me feel judged for being straight/Christian/traditional"
- "Made me feel unwelcome for not agreeing with the LGBTQ agenda"
- Language framing the instructor's authentic identity as a hostile act against the student

Key citations: CBE Life Sciences (2024); Boston University SPH (2024)

12F. Transgender and Nonbinary-Specific Language

Gender identity that does not overtly conform to the binary likely complicates evaluations of teaching further than the existing body of knowledge has even identified (Kreitzer & Sweet-Cushman, 2021).

Phrases:

- Deliberate misgendering in evaluation language (*use of wrong pronouns or name*)
- Comments expressing confusion, amusement, or hostility toward the instructor's gender identity
- Complaints about pronouns framed as a class management issue
- Language suggesting the instructor's gender identity is a distraction from learning
- "Made class about their gender stuff" / "kept talking about pronouns"
- "Unprofessional to bring up personal gender issues in class"

Key citations: Kreitzer & Sweet-Cushman (2021); Inside Higher Ed (2023); CBE Life Sciences (2024)

12G. Intersectional LGBTQ+ Bias

Misawa (2015) found that gay Latino and Black male faculty received homophobic evaluations, were excluded from professional collaborations, and had their professional opinions dismissed.

Training signal: Evaluations of LGBTQ+ faculty of color should be analyzed for both anti-LGBTQ+ and race-based bias simultaneously, recognizing compound effects greater than either alone.

Key citations: Misawa (2015); Frontiers in Education (2024); Anderson & Kanner (2011)

(Type 3 — Stigmatized Identity Bias; NEW CATEGORY)

This category addresses bias rooted not in general racial or accent categories, but in the specific social meanings attached to a particular national origin or ethnicity that has been systematically stigmatized in the broader culture. The research on "cultural bias" in SETs has typically defined it through country of birth or language spoken at home (Fan et al., 2019), but this measurement framework fails to capture faculty whose ethnic identity is stigmatized *independently of language* — where the instructor speaks fluent, unaccented English but their national origin activates specific cultural stereotypes.

Cultural bias in student evaluations captures the combination of biases related to language background, embodiment or presentation of presumed racial/ethnic identity, and beliefs or conventions particular to a given cultural context (Fan et al., 2019). Biases creep in specifically when students evaluate the person, not the course (St. Olaf IEA, 2025). The illustrative case developed in this section is **anti-Haitian bias**, which serves as a template for understanding how any heavily stigmatized national identity generates a distinct evaluative bias pattern.

13A. The Mechanism: Disgust-Organized Stigma

Unlike general racial bias, which tends to be organized around anger and contempt, bias against groups historically coded as disease-carrying, primitive, or contaminant-bearing activates the distinct emotion of **disgust**. Research on the behavioral immune system establishes that disgust sensitivity, which evolved as protection against pathogen threats, also triggers reactions to social cues associated with stigmatized groups — particularly groups culturally coded around disease (Kusche & Barker, 2019).

Anti-Haitian bias in the United States is specifically organized around disease (the CDC's wrongful designation of Haitians as an AIDS risk group in the 1980s; tuberculosis rumors in the 1970s), primitivism (voodoo stereotypes), and the "forever foreigner" designation — all of which activate disgust rather than anger as the primary emotional mechanism (UUSC, 2025; The Intercept, 2024).

Training implication: Bias organized around disgust may manifest differently than bias organized around contempt or anger. Evaluators should look for language suggesting aversion, avoidance, contamination anxiety, or disproportionate discomfort — language that would be unusual as pedagogical feedback but consistent with the disgust emotional response.

Key citations: Pascal et al. (2023); Kusche & Barker (2019); Hodson et al. (2013); UUSC (2025)

13B. Disgust-Organized Language in Evaluations

Phrases suggesting disgust-organized bias:

- Any language suggesting physical aversion, avoidance, or discomfort with the instructor's presence without pedagogical cause
- Descriptions of the classroom as "uncomfortable," "unwelcoming," or "hostile" without specific pedagogical cause
- Language suggesting the evaluator wanted to minimize contact or interaction
- Disproportionate emotional intensity relative to the stated complaint
- Language evoking contamination, dirtiness, or moral taint

Key citations: Pascal et al. (2023); Hodson et al. (2013); Kusche & Barker (2019)

13C. "Forever Foreigner" Markers

The "forever foreigner" trope marks faculty as permanently outside the national or institutional community regardless of citizenship, language fluency, or years of residence. This trope generates evaluation language marking the instructor as not belonging even when their English is fluent and their credentials are unimpeachable.

Phrases — applicable to native English-speaking faculty with stigmatized national identities:

- "Not what I expected"
- "Doesn't fit here" / "Hard to relate to"
- "Very different from what I'm used to"
- "Seems out of place" / "Not like other professors"
- "Surprising for someone in this position"
- Language referencing the instructor's national origin, country of birth, or cultural background in an evaluative context

Key citations: Vox (2024); IBW21 (2024); Fan et al. (2019)

13D. Political Context Amplification

When political rhetoric at the national level actively amplifies stigma against a specific national or ethnic group, the evaluative environment for faculty of that background worsens directly and measurably. Racialized and xenophobic disinformation reinforces an anti-Black and anti-immigrant vision of America, and the persistent effects of that disinformation dehumanize specific national groups as unworthy members of the polity (Harvard Law Review, 2024).

Key citations: Harvard Law Review (2024); The Intercept (2024); Common Dreams (2024)

13E. Culturally Coded Content Complaints

When a faculty member's stigmatized national or ethnic identity is known or visible, complaints about course content related to that identity or culture function as attacks on the instructor's legitimacy:

- Dismissal of course content related to stigmatized cultures as "not real scholarship"
- Framing of cultural practices associated with the instructor's ethnicity as exotic, dangerous, or irrational
- Complaints that the course was "propaganda" or "indoctrination" when it addresses history related to the instructor's cultural background
- "Too focused on [specific country/region/culture]"
- "That history isn't relevant to us"
- "Why are we learning about [place] in this class?"

Key citations: Lazos (2012); Gutiérrez y Muhs et al. (2012); Fan et al. (2019)

13F. Intersectional Compounding: Race + National Stigma

Haitian faculty, for example, face compound marginalization from both the structural racism experienced by all Black Americans and the specific ethnic stigma attached to Haitian identity — a double marginalization that the existing SET bias literature has not yet adequately measured (The Conversation, 2024). The compound effect of race and ethnic stigma is greater than either alone.

Training implication: AI models should detect both general anti-Black language patterns (Category 6) *and* ethnicity-specific stigma language simultaneously when evaluating comments about faculty from doubly stigmatized groups.

Key citations: The Conversation (2024); Pascal et al. (2023); Crenshaw (1989)

(Type 4 — Deliberate Defamation; NEW CATEGORY)

The literature documents a spectrum of harmful conduct in student evaluations ranging from unconscious bias at one end to deliberate, targeted reputational attacks at the other. A survey of 674 academics found that the highest volume, most derogatory, and most threatening abuse is directed towards women academics and those academics from marginalised groups (Heffernan, 2023). Previous estimates of the rate and severity of abusive comments that academics receive, and the impact to academics' wellbeing, mental health, and career progression, have underestimated the true scale of the problem.

This category requires a different institutional response than implicit bias: not just flagging for review, but active investigation, protection of the faculty member, and in some cases legal action.

14A. The Anonymity Problem: Structural Enablement

According to the Pew Research Center, 89 percent of Americans say the ability to post anonymously online enables people to be cruel to or harass one another. The culture of normalizing ad hominem attacks and general online incivility bleeds over to classroom conduct, which is then reflected in anonymous student evaluations. Within this platform of evaluations, students are at liberty to say whatever they want with no repercussions (Burke & Spurgeon, 2020).

SETs can be weaponized to justify undermining academic freedom and subjecting untenured and contingent faculty to surveillance and bullying. SETs are a particularly adaptable weapon because the data can be interpreted to justify a range of positions (Rodriguez, AAUP, 2019).

Key citations: Burke & Spurgeon (2020); Rodriguez/AAUP (2019); Heffernan (2023)

14B. Academic Contrapower Harassment (ACPH)

Academic contrapower harassment (ACPH) occurs when someone with seemingly less power in an educational setting — a student — harasses someone more powerful — a professor.

Approximately 45 percent of faculty reported receiving hostile course evaluations, and about 25 percent had received some type of hostile or threatening communication (Lampman et al., 2009). Women faculty reported that students were more likely to challenge their authority, argue or refuse to follow course policies, and exhibit disrespectful or disruptive behaviors.

Phrases indicating ACPH in evaluations:

- Sexually explicit comments about the instructor
- Explicit threats or intimidating language

- Comments targeting the instructor's family, personal life, or off-campus identity
- Personal insults unrelated to any pedagogical observation
- Profanity directed at the instructor personally
- "I HATE YOU" / "I HATE EVERYTHING ABOUT YOU" type language

Key citations: Lampman et al. (2009, 2012); Burke & Spurgeon (2020); Inside Higher Ed (2018)

14C. Unadjudicated Misconduct Accusations

False or unadjudicated accusations of misconduct in student evaluations are among the most dangerous forms of defamatory content because they appear as legitimate complaints and may flow directly into personnel decisions without investigation. Students directly challenge particular faculty in class, sometimes through verbal and even physical abuse, and write insensitive and irrelevant race- and gender-based comments on anonymous teaching evaluations (Deo, 2015).

Phrases constituting potentially defamatory misconduct accusations:

- Accusations of discrimination against specific student groups (*without investigation*)
- Claims that the instructor graded retaliatorily or punitively
- Accusations of sexual harassment or inappropriate conduct
- Claims that the instructor violated institutional policy
- Accusations of plagiarism, academic dishonesty, or research misconduct
- Claims the instructor threatened, intimidated, or harassed students
- Accusations of retaliation for student complaints
- Claims the instructor is racist, sexist, or homophobic (*as factual assertions, not opinions*)

Key citations: Deo (2015); NACUA (n.d.); Nesenoff & Miltenberg LLP (2020)

14D. False Factual Claims About Pedagogy

Phrases constituting potentially false factual claims:

- Claims that assignments were never explained when they were
- Claims that grading criteria were never provided when documented evidence contradicts this
- Claims that the instructor was absent or unprepared when records contradict this
- Claims that the instructor refused to answer questions or meet with students
- Fabricated accounts of in-class incidents

Key citations: Deo (2015); NACUA (n.d.); ATIXA (2021)

14E. Coordinated or Patterned Attacks

Harassment is coordinated out in the open on anonymous, uncensored forums like 4chan, 8chan, and Reddit, where self-identified "trolls" uncover and post people's personal information and try out strategies of attack (Kamenetz/NPR, 2018). The same dynamics that produce coordinated online harassment of faculty can also manifest within anonymous SET instruments.

Coordination signals for AI detection:

- Multiple evaluations in the same term using identical or near-identical language
- Sudden spike in negative evaluations following a grading event or classroom confrontation
- Evaluations referencing specific incidents that other evaluations also reference (*suggesting coordination*)
- Uniform use of specific accusatory phrases across multiple otherwise different evaluations
- Evaluations that reference events or statements outside the classroom (*social media, news coverage*)

Key citations: Kamenetz/NPR (2018); McKay et al. (2021); Rodriguez/AAUP (2019)

14F. Grade Retaliation as Motivated Defamation

If a student is dissatisfied with a faculty member — for example, due to a low grade given — a harassment complaint or a highly negative evaluation provides an easy opening to get retribution (Nesenoff & Miltenberg LLP, 2020).

Signals of grade retaliation:

- Evaluations submitted immediately after grade disputes or grade appeals
- Evaluations that reference specific grades or grading decisions by name
- Sudden transition from neutral or positive prior evaluations to highly negative evaluations in the same semester, correlated with a grading event
- Language explicitly connecting the negative evaluation to a grade received

Key citations: Nesenoff & Miltenberg LLP (2020); Burke & Spurgeon (2020); Kogan et al. (2022)

14G. Institutional Weaponization

Student evaluations are sometimes deliberately wielded at the institutional level — by

administrators, departments, and colleagues — to disadvantage minoritized faculty, using biased student data as laundered, apparently objective evidence. Student evaluations have been used to try to kill the chances of tenure for a Hispanic female professor who had already won a teaching award (LawProfBlawg, Above the Law, 2018).

Key citations: LawProfBlawg/Above the Law (2018); Rodriguez/AAUP (2019); Deo (2019)

CATEGORY 15: Absence of Positive Language as a Bias Signal

(Type 1 — Direct Identity Bias)

Schmidt (2015) and MacNell et al. (2014) document that positive intellectual descriptors — "brilliant," "genius," "inspiring" — appear significantly more often in evaluations of white male faculty than in evaluations of women or faculty of color, even when teaching performance is equivalent or identical. The systematic absence of these terms in evaluations of minoritized faculty is itself a measurable bias signal detectable through comparative analysis.

Terms appearing significantly less often in evaluations of minoritized faculty:

- brilliant, genius, expert, inspiring, knowledgeable
- awesome, incredible, funny, entertaining, engaging
- clear, articulate, confident, authoritative
- natural teacher, best professor I've had
- very professional, commands respect

Key citations: Schmidt (2015); MacNell et al. (2014); Boring et al. (2016); Chávez & Mitchell (2020)

Notes for AI Training Implementation

1. Four-Type Detection Framework

The model should be trained to detect and distinguish between:

- **Type 1 (Direct Bias):** Identity-based language targeting personality, appearance, accent, authority, or cultural background
- **Type 2 (Proxy Bias):** Pedagogically framed language that research demonstrates is contaminated by instructor identity
- **Type 3 (Stigmatized Identity Bias):** Language activating specific cultural stereotypes associated with a particular national origin, ethnicity, sexual orientation, or gender identity

- **Type 4 (Deliberate Defamation):** Fabricated accusations, coordinated attacks, unadjudicated misconduct claims, and targeted harassment

Types 1 and 3 should be flagged for bias review. Type 2 requires additional contextual analysis. **Type 4 requires immediate escalation, protective action, and potential legal referral — not just bias review.**

2. Context Sensitivity Is Essential

These terms are not automatically evidence of bias in every instance. The model should flag for human review, not render final judgments. A complaint about late feedback from a single student may be legitimate; the same complaint appearing repeatedly in evaluations of a minoritized instructor but not in evaluations of white male peers in comparable courses is a significant signal (Chávez & Mitchell, 2020).

3. Comparison Across Instructors Is the Key Analytical Move

Bias is most detectable when all course elements are held constant and differential outcomes still emerge by instructor identity (Chávez & Mitchell, 2020). The model should be trained to flag not just individual evaluations but patterns across evaluations — particularly when the same pedagogical practices generate positive comments for white male instructors and negative comments for minoritized instructors.

4. Clustering Increases Signal Strength

Multiple indicators within a single evaluation, or patterns repeated across multiple evaluations of the same instructor, significantly increase the likelihood that bias is present (Heffernan, 2022). A single complaint about "unclear rubrics" may be noise; five complaints about rubrics combined with complaints about tone, relatability, and political content is a cluster worth flagging.

5. Post-Grade Timing Elevates Proxy Bias Risk

Bias widens significantly after grades are received (Inside Higher Ed, 2022). When evaluations are administered after grading, all pedagogical dissatisfaction complaints should be weighted with additional caution.

6. Intersectionality Compounds Bias

Evaluations of Black women, women of color with non-native accents, LGBTQ+ faculty of color, or faculty from heavily stigmatized national backgrounds may contain overlapping indicator categories simultaneously, and the compounding effect is greater than any single identity dimension alone (Crenshaw, 1989; Heffernan, 2022).

7. Open-Ended Comments Carry the Highest Risk

Research consistently identifies free-text fields as the site of the strongest and most harmful bias in SETs. Administrators are urged to restrict or eliminate the use of qualitative or write-in

comments, which have the "strongest evidence of equity bias" (Inside Higher Ed, 2021).

8. The Double-Bind of Rigor Requires Comparative Analysis

The rigor double-bind is detectable only through comparison: when the same grading standards or workload generate "unfair/too hard" complaints for a minoritized instructor but not for white male peers teaching comparable courses, the complaint reflects identity bias rather than pedagogical failure. The success inversion is detectable when students describe learning gains while simultaneously attributing those gains to themselves rather than the instructor.

9. LGBTQ+ Bias Requires Disclosure-Sensitive Analysis

Because LGBTQ+ identity is frequently concealable, evaluative patterns may shift abruptly when identity becomes visible. AI models should be trained to detect these abrupt shifts as potential disclosure-retaliation signals. **Misgendering in evaluations is not a neutral error — it is targeted harassment and should be treated as Type 4.**

10. Stigmatized National Identity Bias Requires Identity-Specific Training

Standard racial bias detection may not capture ethnic-specific stigma that operates through disgust rather than contempt. AI models should be trained on the specific content of anti-Haitian, anti-Arab, anti-Roma, and other historically stigmatized group stereotypes to detect when those stereotypes appear in evaluation language — even in the absence of general racial bias markers.

11. Type 4 Content Requires Immediate Escalation

Any evaluation containing unadjudicated misconduct accusations, sexually explicit content, threats, fabricated factual claims, or coordination signals should be flagged as Type 4 and escalated immediately to human reviewers and institutional compliance officers — not included in personnel file summaries, not averaged into numerical scores, and not presented to the faculty member as formative feedback before protective review.

12. Never Use SETs as the Sole Metric for Minoritized Faculty

Given the well-documented potential for harm across all four bias types, SETs should never be used as the singular or primary measure of teaching effectiveness for minoritized faculty. Peer observation, self-evaluation, teaching portfolios, and documented pedagogical revisions are recommended as supplementary or alternative measures (Chronicle, 2024; UNC Charlotte ADVANCE, 2023).

CATEGORY 16: The Credibility Inversion — Contextualizing Pedagogical Signals Against Teaching Experience and Expertise

(Type 2 — Proxy Bias; Intersects with Types 1, 3, and 4; NEW CATEGORY)

Overview

This category addresses one of the most structurally dangerous and undertheorized dynamics in SET bias: the **credibility inversion problem** — the phenomenon in which negative pedagogical feedback about course design, instructional clarity, or assessment construction is treated as an actionable signal even when it directly contradicts a faculty member's documented expertise, years of teaching experience, and scholarly record. For highly credentialed, experienced minoritized faculty, this inversion represents a compounding injustice: the more expertise a faculty member has demonstrated, the more implausible student-generated criticisms of that expertise become — and yet, for women, faculty of color, and faculty from stigmatized ethnic backgrounds, those criticisms are routinely accepted uncritically by administrators and review committees.

The research establishes that older female instructors were rated lower than younger women, with students rating the same women more poorly over time, even as these professors were gaining teaching experience (Inside Higher Ed, 2022). This is the temporal signature of bias, not instructional decline: experience that should reduce the plausibility of "poor teaching" complaints instead has no protective effect — and may intensify bias as more experienced women become more pedagogically authoritative and therefore more threatening to students' racialized and gendered expectations.

For faculty who occupy multiple stigmatized identity positions simultaneously — for example, a Black, Haitian woman with 20 years of teaching experience and published expertise in pedagogical innovation — the compound identity risk multiplier means that:

1. Anti-Black racial bias produces the lowest evaluation scores of any racial group, including persistent authority challenges and presumption of incompetence in pedagogical domains (Smith & Hawkins, 2011; Gutiérrez y Muhs et al., 2012)
2. Anti-Haitian ethnic stigma activates a disgust-organized bias mechanism — rooted in historically specific disease-contamination associations and primitivism stereotypes — that generates evaluative discomfort expressed as pedagogical dissatisfaction (Pascal et al., 2023; Kusche & Barker, 2019)
3. Gender bias produces disproportionate scrutiny of organization, structure, and professionalism — exactly the pedagogical domains in which complaints most commonly appear — along with greater penalties for rigor and higher emotional labor expectations (Boring et al., 2016; Sprague & Massoni, 2005)

The compound effect of these three systems is not additive — it is multiplicative, and it is not captured by existing SET bias measurement instruments, which means the literature systematically underestimates the magnitude of bias faced by faculty at this intersection.

16A. The Expertise Paradox

The expertise paradox occurs when an instructor's published scholarly record, documented training, or recognized expertise directly contradicts the substance of student pedagogical complaints. This paradox is diagnostic: when a faculty member who has published on course design receives persistent student complaints about course design, the prior probability that those complaints reflect genuine pedagogical deficiency — rather than bias — is dramatically reduced.

The evidentiary hierarchy relevant to this paradox:

Peer-reviewed publications on pedagogical methods constitute a higher-quality form of evidence about pedagogical competence than anonymous student ratings, because:

- Peer review applies expert-level scrutiny using explicit criteria
- Publications are evaluated by scholars with relevant disciplinary and pedagogical expertise
- Published work demonstrates prospective expertise — the faculty member has studied, theorized, and contributed to knowledge in the exact domain being criticized
- Anonymous student evaluations are produced by individuals with no training in pedagogical assessment, using no expertise criteria, in an instrument documented to carry systematic identity-based bias

AI training signal: When a faculty member's professional record includes publications, awards, recognitions, or formal training in domains being criticized in SETs, those criticisms should be flagged as high-probability bias artifacts requiring independent corroboration before any administrative action.

Key phrases indicating expertise paradox:

- Student complaints about "disorganized" courses from a faculty member with publications on course design
- Student complaints about "unclear assessments" from a faculty member with expertise in assessment design
- Student complaints about "confusing explanations" from a faculty member with 15+ years of teaching experience and documented positive outcomes
- Student complaints about "no clear rubric" from a faculty member whose published work addresses rubric design or assessment transparency

Key citations: Gutiérrez y Muhs et al. (2012); Inside Higher Ed (2022); Boring et al. (2016); Sprague & Massoni (2005)

16B. The Corroboration Gap

A pedagogical complaint in a SET cannot be treated as an actionable signal unless it is corroborated by at least one independent source of evidence not subject to the same student-identity-perception dynamic that produces the bias in the first place. The absence of such corroboration is not a neutral finding — it is itself evidence that the complaint has not been verified and should not inform personnel decisions.

The Corroboration Test — by complaint domain:

SET Complaint Domain	Independent evidence required for corroboration	Independent evidence that refutes the complaint
Course disorganization	Peer reviewer finds incoherent syllabus, missing objectives, absent sequencing	Published syllabi show clear structure; peer observation confirms organized delivery; SoTL publications demonstrate design expertise
Unclear rubrics or assessment criteria	Peer review of rubrics finds vague or missing criteria	Rubrics in teaching portfolio meet or exceed disciplinary standards; published work on assessment design demonstrates expertise
Instructional clarity	Peer observer notes confusing in-class explanations	Peer observation confirms coherent delivery; course materials show logical sequencing
Feedback quality	Peer review of marked student work shows vague comments	Sample marked work in portfolio shows substantive, detailed feedback
Assessment-content misalignment	Exam questions demonstrably outside course content	Exam blueprint shows alignment with stated learning objectives and course content
Due date or scheduling confusion	LMS records show frequent, unexplained changes	LMS records show stable, advance-posted schedule

The diagnostic question for administrators and AI review: Has any complaint category been tested against independent evidence? If not, the SET data is uncontextualized and cannot be treated as an established fact about pedagogy.

Key citations: Esarey & Valdes (2020); UNC Charlotte ADVANCE (2023); St. Olaf IEA (2025); Preprints.org (2025)

16C. The Temporal Stability Problem

For persistent negative pedagogical feedback to be treated as a genuine signal rather than a bias artifact, it must be temporally stable in ways that rule out bias as the primary explanatory mechanism.

Bias-consistent temporal patterns:

- Complaints persist across 10, 15, or 20 years of teaching experience without any corresponding peer-observation corroboration
- Complaint intensity increases over time even as teaching experience accumulates
- Complaints are stable across courses with different content and student populations — suggesting the variable is instructor identity, not the course
- Complaint intensity spikes following grade returns and subsides at other times — consistent with grade retaliation
- Complaints fluctuate with the broader political and social climate affecting the instructor's ethnic or racial group

Genuine pedagogical signal temporal patterns:

- Complaints are concentrated in a specific course, semester, or context
- Complaints decrease as the faculty member addresses specific documented issues
- Peer observation corroborates the timing and nature of complaints
- Complaints are specific, consistent, and not replicated across evaluators who have different identity-based motivations

Key citations: Inside Higher Ed (2022); Boring et al. (2016); Buser et al. (2022); Pascal et al. (2023)

16D. The Three-Type Signal Classification for Experienced and Credentialed Minoritized Faculty

Type A — Potentially Genuine Pedagogical Signal Criteria: corroborated by independent peer observation or materials review; not contradicted by documented expertise; appears with specificity identifying a discrete addressable issue; not correlated with grade returns or identity-related triggering events; replicated across peer observers with different identity relationships to the instructor.

For experienced, credentialed, multiply-stigmatized faculty: Requires substantial and specific independent corroboration across multiple sources. The bar is appropriately calibrated to the elevated prior probability of bias.

Type B — Probable Bias Artifact Criteria: uncorroborated by independent sources; contradicts documented expertise or teaching experience; consistent with documented bias patterns for the instructor's identity position; persistent across courses and populations without specificity; not replicated in evaluations of comparable white male peers teaching equivalent courses.

Administrative response: Document as probable bias artifact; exclude from summative personnel decisions; include in institutional bias pattern record; use to advocate for alternative evaluation instruments and procedures.

Type C — Harassment or Defamatory Signal Criteria: makes false factual claims; constitutes unadjudicated misconduct accusation; is coordinated or patterned; constitutes personal attack disconnected from pedagogical observation; involves misgendering, ethnic slurs, or identity-based abuse.

Administrative response: Immediate escalation; exclude from personnel files; initiate protective review and institutional compliance response; do not present to the faculty member as formative feedback before protective review is complete.

Key citations: Deo (2015); Rodriguez/AAUP (2019); Lampman et al. (2009); NACUA (n.d.)

16E. The Comparative Differential Standard

The most powerful tool for contextualizing SET pedagogical complaints against expertise and experience is systematic comparison of pedagogical complaint rates across instructors of different identities teaching comparable courses. When the same grading standard, course design, or instructional approach generates complaints for a Black Haitian woman but not for a white male peer, the differential is itself evidence of bias.

Key questions for the comparative differential:

- Are white male peers with less experience and less pedagogical expertise receiving equivalent organization and clarity complaints?
- Are white male peers teaching comparable courses with comparable rigor receiving equivalent workload and difficulty complaints?
- Are white male peers who enforce the same grading standards receiving equivalent feedback quality and assessment complaints?

Key citations: Chávez & Mitchell (2020); Smith & Hawkins (2011); Boring et al. (2016); MacNeill et al. (2014)

16F. Counterevidence Portfolio

For AI systems designed to support fair evaluation of teaching, the following categories of

counterevidence should be systematically weighted against pedagogical SET complaints. The presence of this counterevidence does not eliminate the complaints from the record — it contextualizes them as probable bias artifacts and should trigger mandatory human review before any adverse personnel action.

Publication and Scholarship Record:

- Peer-reviewed publications on pedagogy, course design, assessment, or educational innovation (*directly contradicts complaints in those domains*)
- Conference presentations on teaching methods or curriculum design
- Grants or awards related to pedagogical innovation or teaching excellence
- Editorial or peer-review service for pedagogical journals (*demonstrates recognized disciplinary expertise*)

Teaching Record:

- Peer observation reports confirming organized delivery, clear explanations, and effective assessment practices
- Teaching awards or nominations — particularly those involving peer or external review
- Evidence of student learning outcomes: grade distributions, pass rates, subsequent course performance data, alumni feedback
- LMS records demonstrating stable, advance-posted schedules and materials

Course Materials:

- Syllabi demonstrating clear learning objectives, organized structure, and aligned assessment design
- Rubrics meeting or exceeding disciplinary standards for transparency and specificity
- Assignment designs demonstrating coherent scaffolding and explicit connection to learning goals
- Exam blueprints showing alignment between assessed content and course material

Contextual Factors:

- Documentation of the compound identity bias factors applicable to the instructor's position
- Relevant political and social context at the time of evaluation
- Class composition data — student demographics, course level, enrollment patterns
- Grade distribution data at the time of evaluation

Key citations: Kreitzer & Sweet-Cushman (2022); Esarey & Valdes (2020); Preprints.org (2025); UNC Charlotte ADVANCE (2023)

16G. Key Phrases Indicating Credibility Inversion

The following phrases, when appearing in evaluations of faculty with documented pedagogical expertise and extensive teaching experience, should be automatically flagged as high-probability Type B signals requiring independent corroboration before any administrative action:

Organization and Design Complaints — Flagged Against Expertise:

- "The course is disorganized" / "no clear structure" / "I never know what's due"
- "The syllabus doesn't make sense" / "unclear expectations" / "the course is all over the place"
- "No clear learning objectives" / "due dates are confusing"

Assessment and Rubric Complaints — Flagged Against Expertise:

- "Rubrics are unclear" / "I never know what they want" / "grading seems arbitrary"
- "Exams don't match what we studied" / "no clear criteria for success"
- "Hard to know how to get a good grade" / "inconsistent grading"

Instructional Clarity Complaints — Flagged Against Experience:

- "Doesn't explain things clearly" / "hard to follow" / "the lectures are confusing"
- "Doesn't know how to teach" / "seems unprepared" / "doesn't know the material"
- "Hard to understand what they're trying to say"

Key AI diagnostic trigger: When any of these phrases appears in evaluations of a faculty member with 10+ years of teaching experience, relevant pedagogical publications, documented positive peer observations, or teaching awards, flag as credibility inversion requiring mandatory human review and independent corroboration before any personnel action.

16H. AI Implementation Notes for This Category

1. **Credential-sensitivity is essential.** Weight pedagogical complaint plausibility against available faculty record data — years of experience, publication record, peer observation history, awards — before classifying any complaint as a genuine signal.
2. **The compound identity multiplier must be applied.** For faculty whose identity position involves multiple documented bias systems simultaneously, the prior probability of bias is multiplicatively elevated and should calibrate the threshold for treating any complaint as actionable.

3. **Corroboration absence is a finding, not a neutral condition.** When no independent corroboration exists for a persistent pedagogical complaint pattern, flag the absence as itself significant.
 4. **Temporal patterns should be analyzed, not just point-in-time scores.** Detect bias-consistent temporal patterns (complaints increasing over time despite accumulating experience; complaints spiking post-grades) versus genuine-signal temporal patterns.
 5. **The comparative differential should trigger automatic review.** When complaint rates for a faculty member in a documented high-bias-risk identity position exceed those of white male peers teaching comparable courses, trigger automatic flagging for human review.
 6. **Never treat persistent bias artifacts as evidence of persistent deficiency.** Accumulation of bias artifacts is evidence of accumulating bias — not accumulating failure.
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CATEGORY 17: Grade Distributions as Contextual Evidence for Evaluating SET Credibility

(Type 2 — Proxy Bias; Intersects with Categories 10 and 16; NEW CATEGORY)

Overview

Grade distributions — the pattern of grades awarded in a course, including mean GPA, percentage of A/B/C/D/F grades, withdrawal rates, and DFW (D, F, or Withdrawal) rates — constitute one of the most powerful and most underutilized contextual variables for evaluating the credibility of SET scores and pedagogical complaint patterns. The relationship between grades and evaluations is among the most extensively researched dynamics in the SET literature, and its implications run in both directions: grade distributions explain why negative SETs may be artifacts of grading rigor rather than genuine pedagogical failure, and they provide independent, outcome-based evidence of teaching quality that SETs systematically fail to capture.

The core finding, replicated across six major studies using random instructor assignment or multisection designs: in all six studies, SETs were positively correlated with students' grades in the concurrent course. However, when performance in subsequent more advanced courses was used as criterion, course ratings were negatively correlated in five of the studies. Students tend to evaluate more positively the courses in which they did not learn a great deal. Teachers who are more effective in promoting future performance receive worse evaluations from their students (Stroebe, 2020).

17A. The Grade-SET Relationship: What the Research Establishes

The concurrent grade effect — grade satisfaction drives SET scores:

Perceived grading leniency correlates with both the global rating of the instructor ($r = .45$) and the multiple-items SET scale ($r = .45$), suggesting that students reward instructors not for the quality of their teaching but for the generosity of their grading (Stroebe, 2020).

Reliance on SET scores for evaluating teaching may contribute, paradoxically, to a culture of less rigorous education. Students tend to rate more lenient professors more favorably. Professors are rewarded for being less demanding and more lenient graders both by receiving favorable SET ratings and by enjoying higher student enrollment in their courses. Significant grade inflation over the last several decades has coincided with universities increasingly relying on average SET scores to make personnel decisions (AAUP, 2018).

The grading reputation effect:

If a typical instructor decides to adopt a stiffer grading standard, the instructor can expect to see a significant fall in evaluation scores independently of any teaching ability displayed in the classroom. The grades given by an instructor in the previous year have a sizable and significant effect on the student scores the instructor receives in subsequent courses — a "grading reputation effect" with particularly adverse consequences if the instructor graded severely relative to the average grade distribution across the university in the previous year (Evans & Carrell, 2011).

This grading reputation effect is particularly damaging for minoritized faculty who maintain high standards across years: their reputation as rigorous graders follows them from course to course, producing persistently depressed SET scores that have nothing to do with pedagogical quality.

The follow-on course inversion:

Professors who excel at promoting contemporaneous student achievement teach in ways that improve their student evaluations but harm the follow-on achievement of their students. Academic rank, teaching experience, and terminal degree are positively correlated with follow-on course performance, though negatively related to student evaluations (Carrell & West, 2010).

The analysis of data from Bocconi University in Italy showed a negative correlation between teachers' true effectiveness — measured by how well their students did in subsequent courses — and the evaluations those teachers received (Braga et al., 2014).

Key citations: Carrell & West (2010); Braga et al. (2014); Stroebe (2020); Evans & Carrell (2011); Kogan et al. (2022)

17B. What Grade Distributions Reveal About SET Credibility

Grade distributions function as a contextual lens through which SET scores can be evaluated for plausibility.

Framework 1: Low grades + negative SETs Most plausible interpretation: **grade dissatisfaction driving evaluative retaliation** rather than genuine pedagogical deficiency. For minoritized faculty, this pattern is compounded by the documented finding that women and faculty of color are penalized more severely than white male peers for identical grading decisions.

AI training signal: When low SET scores co-occur with low mean GPA or high DFW rates, and when comparable white male peers with similar grade distributions receive higher SET scores, flag as probable grade-retaliation bias artifact.

Framework 2: High grades + negative SETs Most plausible interpretation: **identity-based bias operating independently of grade outcomes**. This pattern cannot be explained by grade dissatisfaction. It demonstrates that the bias is about instructor identity, not grades.

AI training signal: When negative SETs persist despite high grade distributions, flag as high-probability Type 1 or Type 3 bias.

Framework 3: Low grades + positive SETs Most plausible interpretation: White male instructor whose social authority insulates them from grade-based retaliation, or whose rigor is coded as intellectual seriousness. When this pattern occurs for white male peers but Framework 1 occurs for minoritized faculty teaching equivalent courses, the differential is evidence of identity-based bias.

Framework 4: High grades + positive SETs Consistent with genuine excellence OR strategic grade leniency. Requires independent corroboration before being treated as evidence of superior teaching.

17C. The Grade Distribution — SET Credibility Matrix

Grade Distribution Pattern	SET Pattern	Most Probable Interpretation	AI Flag
Low mean GPA / high DFW	Negative SETs	Grade-retaliation bias artifact	Flag: require independent corroboration before treating as actionable
Low mean GPA / high DFW	Positive SETs	Rigor valued — possible evidence of teaching quality	No flag; consider follow-on performance data
High mean GPA / low DFW	Negative SETs	Identity-based bias (not grade-driven)	Flag: high-probability Type 1 or Type 3 bias
High mean GPA / low DFW	Positive SETs	Genuine effectiveness OR grade inflation	No flag; corroborate with follow-on performance

Grade Distribution Pattern	SET Pattern	Most Probable Interpretation	AI Flag
Average GPA / negative SETs	Negative SETs	May reflect identity bias or specific course issues	Flag if identity-position is high-risk; require peer comparison
Same grades, worse SETs than white male peer	Any negative	Grade-retaliation compound identity bias	Flag; comparative differential standard triggered

17D. DFW Rates: A Double-Edged and Frequently Misused Metric

DFW rates — the percentage of students receiving D grades, F grades, or withdrawals — have increasingly been used as independent measures of teaching effectiveness, with some institutions using high DFW rates as grounds for adverse personnel action. This use is contested, methodologically unsound, and particularly damaging for minoritized faculty who teach more challenging courses or who serve student populations facing higher structural barriers.

The institutional misuse of DFW rates:

Professors at Savannah State University, Georgia's oldest historically Black institution, objected to a new, unwritten policy judging their teaching effectiveness by how many D or F grades they give. The use of DFW rates to measure teaching effectiveness is controversial across academe, with critics saying there is little to no peer-reviewed evidence that high failure rates and poor instruction are linked. Making DFW rates a formal measure of good teaching may pressure professors into passing students who haven't earned it (Inside Higher Ed, 2018).

The Savannah State case is significant because it occurred at an HBCU — a context in which the faculty most likely to be penalized by a DFW-rate policy are Black faculty maintaining rigorous academic standards for Black students.

What DFW rates actually measure:

DFW rates are confounded by at least four variables independent of teaching quality:

1. Student preparation and entry-level competency
2. Course difficulty and disciplinary norms — STEM courses and gateway courses have systematically higher DFW rates
3. Grading standards — instructors who maintain standards produce higher DFW rates than those who inflate grades
4. Student support infrastructure — availability of tutoring, advising, and financial support

The proper use of DFW rates in SET contextualization:

- A high DFW rate in a course with low SET scores suggests grade-dissatisfaction bias rather than genuine pedagogical failure
- A high DFW rate should be compared against departmental norms for that specific course — not institution-wide averages
- A persistent high DFW rate across multiple sections taught by different instructors suggests the course design, not any individual instructor, is the issue

Key citations: Inside Higher Ed (2018); Uttl et al. (2017); Stroebe (2020); SIUE Grade Analytics (n.d.)

17E. Follow-On Course Performance: The Gold Standard for Teaching Effectiveness

The strongest available evidence for genuine teaching effectiveness — superior to SET scores, concurrent grade distributions, and DFW rates — is student performance in follow-on courses that build on the content taught in the evaluated course. This evidence is the gold standard because it measures durable learning rather than immediate satisfaction, is not subject to the identity-based perception dynamics that contaminate SETs, and reflects the long-term outcome that education is actually for.

Academic rank, teaching experience, and terminal degree are positively correlated with follow-on course performance, though negatively related to student evaluations (Carrell & West, 2010). This is precisely the pattern expected for experienced, credentialed minoritized faculty: their superior qualifications produce better long-term student outcomes, but their identity position produces worse contemporaneous evaluations.

How follow-on course performance should be used:

- Do students who completed this faculty member's prerequisite course perform better in the follow-on course compared to students who took other sections?
- Do students who completed this faculty member's gateway course show higher rates of continuing in the major or discipline?
- Do alumni who took courses with this faculty member report higher levels of preparation for professional or graduate-level work?

When follow-on performance data shows that students from a course with low SET scores perform better subsequently than students from courses with high SET scores, this is direct evidence that the low SET scores reflect satisfaction bias rather than genuine pedagogical deficiency.

Key citations: Carrell & West (2010); Braga et al. (2014); Kornell & Hausman (2016); Preprints.org (2025)

17F. The Grade Inflation Trap

A documented institutional dynamic compounds the harm to minoritized faculty who maintain rigorous grading standards: the pressure to improve SET scores creates an incentive structure that rewards grade inflation and punishes academic integrity. Direct evidence comes from a study where 38% of professors confessed they had intentionally made their courses easier in response to student evaluations (Preprints.org, 2025).

For minoritized faculty, this pressure is asymmetric and more severe:

1. **Higher grade-retaliation susceptibility.** Women and faculty of color are penalized more severely for the same grading decisions as white male peers.
2. **Credential-competence catch-22.** A minoritized faculty member who reduces rigor to improve SET scores undermines the academic seriousness that their scholarly credentials represent.
3. **The DFW policy trap.** When institutions use high DFW rates as grounds for adverse action, minoritized faculty face a choice between maintaining standards and inflating grades — neither without professional cost.
4. **Long-term student harm.** Students who receive inflated grades are less prepared for follow-on courses — a harm that falls disproportionately on students of minoritized faculty who face the greatest pressure to inflate.

Key citations: Preprints.org (2025); AAUP (2018); Stroebe (2020); Inside Higher Ed (2018)

17G. Practical Protocol: Using Grade Distributions to Contextualize SET Credibility

For administrators, review committees, and AI systems using SET data in any personnel context:

Step 1: Obtain the grade distribution (mean GPA, distribution by letter grade, DFW rate, withdrawal rate) for each course for which SET data is being considered.

Step 2: Establish departmental and course-level norms. Compare against norms for that specific course — not institution-wide averages.

Step 3: Apply the comparative differential standard. Compare grade distribution and SET scores against white male peers teaching equivalent courses at equivalent rigor.

Step 4: Check for the grade-retaliation signature. Are negative evaluations concentrated in courses where grades are low? Does this pattern exceed what is observed for white male peers?

Step 5: Examine follow-on course performance where available. Superior follow-on performance from a section with low SET scores is direct evidence that the low SETs reflect satisfaction bias.

Step 6: Apply the DFW context test. Is the DFW rate anomalous for that course type? Does it reflect student preparation deficits? Is it corroborated by peer observation? Are equivalent rates in courses taught by white male peers treated equivalently?

Key citations: Carrell & West (2010); Kogan et al. (2022); Evans & Carrell (2011); Inside Higher Ed (2018); UNC Charlotte ADVANCE (2023)

17H. Key Phrases Reflecting Grade Dissatisfaction Rather Than Genuine Pedagogy

The following phrases, when appearing in evaluations from courses with low mean GPA or high DFW rates, should be flagged as probable grade-dissatisfaction artifacts rather than genuine pedagogical signals:

Direct grade-retaliation language:

- "Grading is unfair" / "I deserved a better grade" / "the grading doesn't reflect my effort"
- "Penalizes students for not being perfect" / "set students up to fail"
- "Impossible to get a good grade no matter what you do" / "standards are unreasonably high"
- "Doesn't give partial credit" / "nitpicks everything" / "the curve wasn't enough"
- "Doesn't take into account how hard students worked"
- Any explicit reference to specific grades received

Grade-dissatisfaction displacement — complaints reframed as pedagogy:

- "Doesn't explain things clearly" (*appearing specifically in low-grade sections*)
- "Rubrics are unclear" (*appearing after graded work is returned, not before*)
- "Exams don't match what we studied" (*when exam blueprints show clear alignment*)
- "Hard to follow in class" (*appearing specifically in low-grade sections but not high-grade sections of same instructor*)

AI training signal for grade-retaliation detection: Flag any SET comment containing explicit grade references or grade-dissatisfaction language when: (1) the course has a below-departmental-norm mean GPA or above-norm DFW rate; (2) the instructor is in a documented high-identity-bias-risk position; and (3) the complaint category does not appear in the same instructor's evaluations from courses with higher grade distributions.

17I. AI Implementation Notes for This Category

1. **Grade distribution data should be integrated into SET analysis as a mandatory contextual variable.** No SET score or qualitative comment pattern should be evaluated for

personnel purposes without corresponding grade distribution data for that course and term.

2. **The comparative differential standard applies to grade distributions as well as SET scores.** When equivalent grade distributions produce worse SET scores for a minoritized instructor than for white male peers, the differential is a bias signal.
 3. **DFW rates should never be used as independent evidence of poor teaching** without peer observation corroboration and course-type normalization.
 4. **Follow-on course performance data should be weighted more heavily than contemporaneous SET scores** in any summative teaching evaluation. When available, this data provides the most valid available measure of teaching effectiveness.
 5. **Grade inflation as a response to SET pressure should be treated as an institutional harm signal**, not a teaching improvement signal. When an instructor's grade distributions shift upward in correlation with SET score improvements following institutional pressure, this suggests strategic grade leniency rather than pedagogical development.
 6. **The grade-retaliation signature is compound for minoritized faculty.** Women and faculty of color experience greater grade-retaliation backlash than white male peers for identical grading decisions. The threshold for treating low-GPA-correlated negative SETs as actionable must be calibrated to this documented asymmetry.
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